

**Weekly Business Session: September 2, 2026**

**9:00 a.m. - Anne G. Basker Auditorium, 600 N.W. Sixth St, Grants Pass, Oregon**

Present: Ron A. Smith, Chair; Colene M. Martin, Vice-Chair; Gary L. Richardson, Commissioner; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder

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These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

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Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

**1. DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST**

Commissioners Richardson, Martin, and Smith each declared no potential conflicts of interest.

**2. PUBLIC HEARING: Second Reading of Ordinance No. 2026-002; AN ORDINANCE AMENDING THE COMPREHENSIVE PLAN OF JOSEPHINE COUNTY (ORDINANCE 81-11 AS AMENDED) FROM FARM TO RESIDENTIAL AND AMEND THE ZONING MAP OF JOSEPHINE COUNTY (ORDINANCE 85-1 AS AMENDED) FROM FARM RESOURCE (FR) TO RURAL RESIDENTIAL (RR5) AND GOAL EXCEPTION. THE SUBJECT PROPERTY IS IDENTIFIED IN THE JOSEPHINE COUNTY ASSESSOR'S RECORDS AS MAP 35-06-03-D0, TAX LOT (TL) 1400. THE PROPERTY OWNER IS ROSE BUTTE LLC.**

Chair Smith opened the public hearing at 9:01 a.m.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to read Ordinance No. 2026-002 by title only, seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson - Yes, Commissioner Martin - Yes, Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

No additional staff presentation was given at the second reading. The Board noted that the proposal would change the subject property from Farm to Residential on the Comprehensive Plan map and from Farm Resource (FR) to Rural Residential (RR5) on the zoning map.

Judy Ahrens, Josephine County resident, asked whether the change to residential zoning could result in dense apartment-style development. Chair Smith responded that the proposed designation was RR5 rural residential and stated that the property had rocky soils and had not been actively farmed for many years. No other public testimony was offered.

Chair Smith closed the public hearing at 9:03 a.m.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to adopt Ordinance No. 2026-002, seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson - Yes, Commissioner Martin - Yes, Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

**3. PUBLIC HEARING: Board Order No. 2026-048; In the matter of Adopting a Supplemental Budget and Making Appropriations for Fiscal Year 2026-27**

Chair Smith opened the public hearing at 9:04 a.m.

No staff presentation was given. The Board discussed the supplemental budget previously considered by the Budget Committee, including the addition of 6.5 FTE, the effect of recent collective bargaining agreements on staffing costs, and the expectation that Finance would return with additional information regarding the practical impact of those agreements on funded positions.

A written statement from Budget Committee member Chris Collins was read into the record (See attached as Exhibit 1). Mr. Collins explained his opposition to adding \$596,000 for the proposed 6.5 FTE shortly after adoption of the original budget, noting that a number of already-budgeted positions remained vacant and stating his preference that the County first use existing budgeted personnel funding before adding new appropriations. Board discussion noted that most of the proposed positions were supported by grants or other dedicated funding sources and that the General Fund impact was comparatively limited. No other public testimony was offered.

Chair Smith closed the public hearing at 9:10 a.m.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Board Order No. 2026-048, In the matter of Adopting a Supplemental Budget and Making Appropriations for Fiscal Year 2026-27, seconded by Commissioner Smith. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson - Yes, Commissioner Martin - Yes, Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

#### **4. ADMINISTRATIVE ACTION(S) IN CONSIDERATION OF:**

##### **a. Board Order No. 2026-049; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis: Personnel Policy Manual Revision; Travel**

Lita Harper presented Board Order No. 2026-049 and explained that the Travel Policy revision would require preauthorization for overnight in-state travel and would allow advance authorization for recurring in-state meetings. The Board supported the added flexibility, noting that it would reduce repeated approval requests while maintaining appropriate oversight of County travel.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve Board Order No. 2026-049, seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson - Yes, Commissioner Martin - Yes, Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

##### **b. Board Order No. 2026-050; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis: Personnel Policy Manual Revision: Hiring**

Lita Harper presented Board Order No. 2026-050 and explained that the Hiring Policy revision would require vacancies to be advertised nationwide, or as widely as practicable, and would establish more detailed background and criminal-history checks before hiring. The Board emphasized the importance of broad recruitment and thorough screening, particularly for director and management positions that have significant long-term responsibility for County operations.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve Board Order No. 2026-050, seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson - Yes, Commissioner Martin - Yes, Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

##### **c. Board Order No. 2026-047; In the Matter of Uniform Procedure for Setting Fees Charged by County and Setting a Public Hearing: September 16, 2026 District Attorney, Various Fee**

Chair Smith introduced Board Order No. 2026-047, which would set a public hearing for September 16, 2026, regarding proposed revisions to various District Attorney fees. No additional staff presentation was given, and the Board proceeded to consider setting the hearing.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Board Order No. 2026-047, setting a public hearing for September 16, 2026, seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson - Yes, Commissioner Martin - Yes, Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

**5. REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS**

Judy Ahrens, Josephine County resident, discussed juvenile justice and public education. She expressed concern about the relationship between educational outcomes and youth entering the justice system, urged renewed focus on core academic skills, and encouraged public participation in an upcoming Three Rivers School District meeting.

Mark Jones, Josephine County resident, supported making agenda packets available to the public, stating that access to full packets improves transparency and can help citizens identify information relevant to Board decisions. He also encouraged coordinated planning for emergency radio infrastructure among the County, fire districts, the Sheriff, and other agencies.

Debbie Richmond, Josephine County resident, raised concerns regarding horse-racing activities at the Fairgrounds, including alleged animal-welfare issues, stall use, fire-safety conditions, and racing oversight. She asked the County to review matters within its jurisdiction, particularly safety and the Fairgrounds' readiness as an emergency livestock shelter.

**6. BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS**

The Board thanked the speakers. Commissioner Richardson discussed District 7 academic performance and goals, confirmed that agenda packets would be made public with confidentiality safeguards, and said he would gather more information regarding the Fairgrounds concerns and County jurisdiction. Commissioner Martin said emergency communications planning was ongoing and agreed Fairgrounds safety issues warranted review. Chair Smith encouraged continued public involvement and suggested that racing-specific concerns also be submitted to the Oregon Racing Commission.

**7. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR**

Minutes (draft minutes are available for viewing in the board's office):

Land Use Hearing - August 24, 2026

KAJO Radio - August 25, 2026

Board of Commissioner City of Grants Pass - August 25, 2026

Admin Workshop - August 25, 2026

Weekly Business Session - August 26, 2026

Budget Committee Meeting - August 26, 2026

Legal Counsel Update - August 27, 2026

Admin Workshop - August 28, 2026

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve the Consent Calendar, seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson - Yes, Commissioner Martin - Yes, Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

**8. OTHER MATTERS: (ORS 192.640(1) ...notice shall include a list of the principal subjects anticipated to be considered at the meeting, but this requirement shall not limit the ability of a governing body to consider additional subjects.)**

None heard.

**9. ANNOUNCEMENTS**

Commissioner Martin announced that the Whitehorse Park campground ribbon-cutting scheduled for that day had been canceled because of rain and would be rescheduled. Chair Smith welcomed the rainfall but reminded residents that fire season was not over and urged continued caution with fire and other ignition sources.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 9:31 a.m.

  
Nikole Guzman, Recorder

TO: The Josephine County Commissioners  
FROM: Chris Collins - a member of the Josephine County Budget Committee.  
DATE: August 31, 2026  
RE: I will be out of town on September 2, 2026 and unable to attend the meeting. I am asking that one of your read the below message into the record at the September 2, 2026 meeting

My name is Chris Collins. I am a member of the Josephine County Budget Committee. The Committee met last week, on August 26, 2026, to consider a proposal to add funding for 6.5 new full time county employees, which would cost the county \$596,000. This request seeks money over and above the money in the budget that the committee approved and recommended to the Board of County Commissioners approximately just 8 weeks ago.

When this proposal came up last week, I voted no to funding all 6.5 new positions. However, looking back, I don't believe I expressed my reason for voting in opposition to the new positions. I have asked that this statement be read into the record during the public comment portion of today's September 2, 2026 Board of County Commissioners meeting to explain my reasoning for my vote.

By way of background, I think it is important that you know that I was a county employee for almost 32 years, serving as a police officer. During that time, I also served as the president of the rank and file police officer's union. I certainly understand how important and, at times, stressful work on behalf of the citizens of a county can be. I am in total support of a manageable workload as well as a good salary and benefits for all employees, not just government employees. That said, I voted no to funding the requested 6.5 new full time positions. Some 8 weeks ago, the budget committee voted on and passed a county budget after many hours spent attending public meetings and even more hours spent reviewing the budget material at home. The budget that was ultimately approved funded approximately 440 full time county employees. During last week's meeting, I learned that only approximately 396 of the budgeted positions are currently filled. I feel it would be a better fiscal decision to make adjustments whereby the new proposed positions be funded with money already in the approved budget, rather than allotting an additional \$596,000.00 of tax payer's money.

In the event that down the road, all money budgeted for 440 employees is spoken for and more positions are needed, we may then have to consider additional funding. I just think the current proposal is premature given the fact that currently money is budgeted for positions that are not filled.

After having spent many hours with the two other budget committee volunteers and the three county commissioners, I am certain that each of them wants what is the best for the county and for every county employee, and strives to act in a responsible fashion in using tax dollars of the residents of Josephine county. It has been a privilege to work with each of them.

The letter lists three enclosures, and all three are bracketed placeholders rather than actual named files:

1. [Project scope and engineer's estimate, Illinois Valley Industrial Water and Sewer Extension]
2. [Map of the project corridor showing County roads and facilities relative to the proposed designation]
3. [City of Cave Junction current water and wastewater operating figures, August 19, 2026]

The drafting notes page adds two instructions about that list: do not attach the internal "two for one" funding memo, because anything sent to DEQ enters a public rulemaking record and that memo contains candid application strategy; and have counsel review the enclosure list before sending.

Three things worth catching before this goes out.

**Nothing is actually attached yet.** All three items are in brackets, so someone has to produce or locate them. The engineer's estimate and the project scope are asserted to exist in Section 1 ("it is scoped, it has an engineer's estimate"). If they exist, attach them. If they don't yet, that sentence needs softening, because DEQ can ask.

**Request C asks DEQ to rely on documents the letter doesn't provide.** Section 5(C) asks the Department to add the two Business Oregon applications and the resulting facility planning work to the FIS documents-relied-on list. Neither application is enclosed. You are asking an agency to base a fiscal analysis on material it has never seen. Either attach the applications, or say plainly why not (they may contain competitively sensitive or draft content) and offer them on request. As written, the ask is easy to decline for lack of a record.

**Section 1's factual claims rest on the third enclosure alone.** The golf course loading limit and the 2025 treated volume of 136.7 million gallons both trace to the County's Aug. 19 memo reporting City figures, which is enclosure 3. The drafting notes already flag confirming those with Alex Ponder and letting the City review Section 1 first. That matters more than usual here, because the City is the permittee and those numbers put its capacity position into a state rulemaking record.

Separately, the cc list runs to roughly fourteen recipients including the EQC chair and members, two congressional offices, and Curry County. That is not an attachment issue, but it is worth a deliberate decision rather than inheriting the list as drafted. Copying the EQC while asking DEQ staff for accommodation reads differently than a staff-level request, and some recipients may not want to appear on a document they haven't seen.